Customer Onboarding and Implementation Playbook

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Summary. Playbook for onboarding and implementing new Northstar Nexus customers, covering the five phases from kickoff to hypercare, implementation durations by tier, roles, exit criteria, handover to the Customer Success Manager, risk handling, version choices and worked examples.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

This playbook describes how Northstar Systems Private Limited onboards new customers of the Northstar Nexus Platform, Nexus Connect and Nexus Insight, from contract signature to handover to the Customer Success Manager (CSM). It tells Implementation Managers, Solutions Engineers, Support Engineers, CSMs and Engineering staff which phases a project goes through, what must be achieved before a phase can close, who does what, and how to handle delays and risks. Following it consistently gives customers a predictable start and gives Northstar early warning when a project is drifting.

The playbook applies to every new customer implementation and to major expansions that add a new Workspace, region or product module. It does not cover renewals and ongoing account management, which are in CS-008, nor day-to-day support, which is in CS-003. Escalation of implementation problems follows CS-001, and customer messages follow CS-005.

2. Definitions

- **Implementation**: the project that takes a customer from signed contract to a working production use of Nexus.
- **Implementation Manager (IM)**: the Northstar employee accountable for delivering the implementation to scope, time and quality. Enterprise customers get a dedicated IM.
- **Customer Success Manager (CSM)**: the long-term relationship owner after handover. The CSM joins the project at kickoff as an observer.
- **Workspace**: the customer's environment in Nexus where Pipelines run.
- **Pipeline and Connector**: the units of workflow and integration built during technical setup.
- **Pilot**: a limited production-like run with a defined group of users and data to prove the solution.
- **Go-live**: the date on which the customer begins using Nexus for real business processes.
- **Hypercare**: the intensive support period after go-live.

- **Exit criteria**: the conditions that must be true, and recorded, before a phase is closed.
- **Project plan**: the shared plan listing tasks, owners and dates, agreed with the customer at kickoff.

3. Implementation Durations by Tier

Tier	Standard duration	Resourcing
Standard	6 weeks	Shared IM capacity, standard templates
Premier	6 weeks, extendable by agreement	IM assigned for the project, named Solutions Engineer
Enterprise	Up to 12 weeks	Dedicated IM, named Solutions Engineer and Support contact

A standard implementation takes 6 weeks from kickoff to go-live, followed by 30 days of hypercare. Enterprise implementations may take up to 12 weeks because of larger scope, multiple Workspaces, security reviews and integration complexity; the project plan must state the agreed duration at kickoff. Premier projects follow the 6-week pattern unless scope justifies an extension approved by the Director of Implementation. A change in duration after kickoff is a change request and must be recorded and agreed with the customer in writing.

4. Phases Overview

Phase	Timing in a 6-week project	Main purpose
Kickoff	Week 1	Align scope, people, plan and success criteria
Technical setup	Weeks 2-3	Provision, configure, connect and secure
Pilot	Weeks 4-5	Prove with real users and data, fix issues
Go-live	Week 6	Move to production use
Hypercare	30 days after go-live	Stabilise and support closely, then hand over

For Enterprise projects the same five phases apply, but the weeks are stretched in the plan. The order of the phases never changes, and a phase must not start until the previous phase has met its exit criteria, unless the Director of Implementation approves an overlap and records the risk.

5. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Implementation Manager**: owns the plan, runs weekly status meetings, tracks risks, records exit criteria, and reports to the Director of Implementation. Must send a weekly status to the customer's project sponsor.
- **Solutions Engineer**: designs the Workspace structure, Pipelines and Connectors, and advises on data mapping and performance.
- **Customer project sponsor**: the senior customer person who removes obstacles and approves go-live.
- **Customer technical lead**: provides systems access, endpoints, test data and testing resources.
- **CSM**: attends key meetings, builds the relationship and prepares for handover.
- **Support Engineer assigned to the account**: prepares the account in NorthAssist, joins the pilot and hypercare, and ensures that the customer knows how to log cases.

- **Security Desk contact**: answers customer security questionnaires and reviews unusual requirements.
- **Director of Implementation**: approves exceptions to timelines, scope changes and overlaps, and escalates risks to the VP Customer Success.

6. Phase 1: Kickoff (Week 1)

Objectives: confirm what is being delivered, by whom, by when, and how success will be judged.

Activities:

1 Internal handover from Sales to the IM, including the signed order, scope, tier, commitments made in the sales cycle, and known risks. The IM must read the contract's support and uptime terms (see CS-003).
2 Kickoff meeting with the customer's sponsor, technical lead and key users. The IM presents the plan, phases, roles, communication rhythm and success criteria.
3 Agree the success criteria in measurable terms, for example "Order-to-invoice Pipeline processes 95% of orders without manual intervention within 4 weeks of go-live".
4 Confirm the Nexus version to be installed. New implementations should choose a version that is supported for the whole expected life of the project: 5.0 LTS (supported until 2028-02-10) is the usual recommendation for customers wanting stability; 5.1 (supported until 2027-08-18) suits customers who want the newest features and accept the shorter 12-month support period; 4.2 LTS is for customers with existing 4.x integrations. The version 4.3 is no longer supported, since support ended on 2026-06-03, and must not be proposed.
5 Create the account in NorthAssist, record the customer's authorised support contacts, and set up the project record.
6 Share the customer security and data-handling requirements, including who will access which data.

Exit criteria for Kickoff:

- Signed project plan and agreed success criteria.
- Named customer sponsor and technical lead.
- Nexus version and region agreed.
- Risks and assumptions recorded.
- Support contacts registered in NorthAssist.

Example: A Premier customer, a Chennai-based manufacturing group, signs on a Monday. The IM holds the Sales handover on Tuesday, runs the customer kickoff on Thursday, and by Friday the plan, the 5.0 LTS decision and the contact list are agreed. The kickoff phase closes at the end of week 1.

7. Phase 2: Technical Setup (Weeks 2-3)

Objectives: have a secure, configured Workspace with working Connectors and a first draft of every Pipeline.

Activities:

1 Provision the tenant and Workspaces, record the tenant ID and Workspace names.
2 Set up user access, with the customer's identity arrangements, using least privilege. Customer administrators receive admin roles; others receive only what they need.

3 Create API tokens and agree how the customer will rotate and store them. Tokens must never be shared by email or in tickets.
4 Configure Connectors to the customer's systems, check network access, allow-lists and certificates, and test each Connector with a sample call. Record the endpoint's typical latency; if it regularly exceeds the default Connector timeout of 30 seconds, plan for a larger timeout (up to 120 seconds) or for an asynchronous design.
5 Build and unit-test Pipelines with the customer's mapping. Record the schema of each source so later changes can be compared (see CS-002 for NX-4003).
6 Agree rate and volume expectations. The default limit is 1,000 requests per minute per tenant; if peak load is likely to exceed that, record it and discuss options with Product before pilot.
7 Complete any customer security questionnaires with the Security Desk.
8 Train the customer's administrators on Workspace settings, monitoring and the process for logging support cases.

Exit criteria for Technical setup:

- All agreed Connectors tested successfully against the customer's test or sandbox systems.
- Pipelines pass unit tests with sample data.
- User access reviewed and approved by the customer.
- API token handling agreed and documented.
- Security questionnaire answered or open items with owners.
- Pilot scope, users and data agreed.

8. Phase 3: Pilot (Weeks 4-5)

Objectives: demonstrate the solution with real users and representative data, find and fix problems before the whole business depends on it.

Activities:

1 Define the pilot group (for example one plant, one team or 10% of volume) and the duration, normally 2 weeks.
2 Run the Pipelines with real or realistic data. Record every defect and request in a pilot log with severity.
3 Hold a twice-weekly review with the customer technical lead. Fix defects according to severity; critical issues must be fixed before go-live.
4 Measure the agreed success criteria and report the figures weekly.
5 Test failure handling: expired token (NX-1001), slow endpoint (NX-2004), rate limit (NX-3010) and a schema change (NX-4003), so the customer's team knows how the platform behaves.
6 Prepare the go-live plan: cutover steps, rollback approach, responsibilities, communication and timing. Choose a time outside the customer's critical business windows. Avoid month-end and festival peaks unless the customer prefers them.
7 Brief the Support team and make sure the account's priority definitions, hours and contacts are accurate (CS-003).

Exit criteria for Pilot:

- Success criteria met or an agreed plan to meet them.
- No open critical defects; high-severity defects have an agreed fix date.
- Go-live plan and rollback approach approved by the customer sponsor.
- Customer users trained.
- Support readiness confirmed.

Example: During the pilot, an Enterprise customer's logistics Pipeline fails with NX-3010 at 09:00 each morning because all depots send data at the same time. The IM and Solutions Engineer redesign the schedule to stagger depots over 20 minutes and use larger batches. The pilot continues and the success criterion is met in week 5.

9. Phase 4: Go-Live (Week 6)

Objectives: move the solution into real use with controlled risk.

Activities:

1 Run a go/no-go meeting at least 2 business days before the planned date with the customer sponsor, technical lead, IM, Solutions Engineer and the account's Support Engineer. The decision is recorded.
2 Perform the cutover according to the plan. Keep the rollback approach available until the first full business cycle is complete.
3 Monitor the first runs closely. The IM and Solutions Engineer remain on call for the customer for the first 5 business days.
4 Send a go-live notice to the customer's stakeholders, written under the standards in CS-005.
5 Confirm that the support routes work: the customer logs a test case and receives a response within the target for their tier.

Exit criteria for Go-live:

- Production Pipelines run successfully for a full business cycle (for example a day, or a week for weekly processes).
- No open critical or high-severity defects without an agreed plan.
- Support route verified.
- Customer sponsor confirms go-live in writing.

If a go/no-go review finds the solution is not ready, the IM must set a new date within 10 business days where possible, log the reason, and inform the Director of Implementation and the CSM. Go-live must not be forced to meet a date when critical defects remain open.

10. Phase 5: Hypercare (30 Days After Go-Live)

Objectives: stabilise the production service, make sure the customer's teams are confident and prepare the handover.

Activities:

1 Provide an enhanced support arrangement for 30 days: faster contact with the IM or Solutions Engineer, in addition to the standard support route.
2 Hold weekly reviews to examine incidents, support cases, performance and the success criteria.
3 Resolve open items and confirm knowledge transfer: documentation, runbooks, and a list of the customer's Pipelines and Connectors.
4 Review support cases from the period. If the same type of case recurs, create or update a knowledge base article and train the customer.
5 Prepare the handover pack: final configuration, open items, risks, success criteria results, contacts and lessons learned.

Exit criteria for Hypercare and handover:

- The 30 days have passed with no unresolved P1 or P2 case.
- Success criteria reported and accepted.
- Handover pack complete and approved by the Director of Implementation.
- Handover meeting held with the CSM and the customer's sponsor.

Handover to the CSM occurs at the end of hypercare. After handover the CSM owns the relationship, health scoring and the review cycle in CS-008, and the IM remains available for questions for 30 days but does not own new work without a new scope.

11. Managing Risks, Delays and Scope Changes

- **Risk register**: the IM maintains a risk register with likelihood, impact, owner and mitigation, reviewed weekly. Typical risks are late access to customer systems, delayed test data, unclear requirements, and scope increases.
- **Delay**: if a milestone is likely to slip by more than 5 business days, the IM must tell the customer sponsor and the Director of Implementation, document the cause (Northstar or customer) and agree a recovery plan. If delay is caused by the customer, the plan may need a change request.
- **Scope change**: any new Connector, Workspace, region or volume beyond the signed scope is a change request with impact on effort and cost. The IM may not agree to it verbally. Commercial changes must follow the Delegation of Authority in OPS-001.
- **Escalation**: unresolved blockers for more than 5 business days are escalated to the Director of Implementation, then to the VP Customer Success. Customer dissatisfaction follows CS-001.
- **No unconfirmed promises**: no delivery date, feature or customisation may be promised to the customer without Engineering confirmation.

12. Customer Data and Security During Onboarding

During implementation the team may see customer data. The team must follow Northstar's data-handling rules: customer production data is Restricted. It must be shared only through approved tools, must not be sent through personal email or placed in external AI tools, and must not be copied onto laptops unless approved. Where possible, use masked or synthetic data in the pilot. Tokens and secrets must be kept in the approved secrets manager and never in tickets, chat or documents. If personal data is to be processed, a Data Processing Agreement must be in place before any personal data is shared. Any suspicion of a data exposure must be reported to the Security Desk immediately (ext. 5555 or security@northstar-systems.example).

13. Quality Checks and Metrics

The Director of Implementation reviews each project at the end of each phase and tracks the following.

- On-time go-live rate: the share of projects going live on the planned date, with a goal set by management.
- Phase duration against plan.
- Defects found in pilot and after go-live.
- Customer satisfaction scores collected at go-live and at handover.
- Support cases per customer during hypercare.

A short post-implementation review is held within 10 business days of handover with the IM, Solutions Engineer, CSM and Support Engineer to capture lessons and improve templates.

14. Exceptions and Edge Cases

- **Customer wants to go live before pilot exit**: the IM may proceed only if the customer sponsor accepts the risks in writing and the Director of Implementation approves.
- **Two regions**: for customers needing both the Mumbai primary region and the Hyderabad secondary region, the plan must include the extra configuration and test time; for Enterprise this is usually part of the 12-week timeline.
- **Customer-requested delay**: a pause of more than 15 business days requires a revised plan and, where the contract states, new dates.
- **Upgrade during implementation**: if a new version appears during a project, the IM must not upgrade mid-project unless there is a clear need. Supported upgrade paths are 4.2 to 5.0 directly, and 4.3 via 5.0 or 5.1 (4.3 to 5.1 is a supported direct path).
- **Hypercare incident**: a P1 during hypercare follows CS-003 and CS-001 and does not end hypercare; the 30-day clock extends only if the Director of Implementation agrees after a serious incident.
- **Customer on a very small plan**: Standard customers follow the 6-week plan with templates, but the IM may merge technical setup and pilot reviews to avoid meetings that add little value.

15. Related Documents

- CS-003 for support hours and targets, and CS-001 for escalation.
- CS-005 for customer communication standards.
- CS-008 for health score, QBR and renewal activities after handover.
- CS-002 for troubleshooting guidance used during the pilot.

16. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
3.0	2025-08-12	Introduced Enterprise implementation up to 12 weeks
3.1	2025-10-30	Added pilot failure-handling tests
4.0	2026-01-22	Updated version recommendations and handover rules